

D669

Early Literacy Methods

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A four-year-old who loves trucks and has a baby brother holds a picture book upside down and tells the story by looking at the pictures, turning pages from back to front. Which skill should the teacher focus on?

- A. Offer only truck books.
- B. Concepts of print, such as holding the book, where to start, and which way to turn pages.
- C. Phonics patterns such as short vowels.
- D. Reading fluency.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A kindergarten team is planning phonics for the year. Their school has a large garden and a new playground. Which approach best reflects systematic, explicit phonics?

- A. Plan phonics around garden vocabulary.
- B. Follow a planned scope and sequence, teaching each letter-sound directly with daily reading and spelling practice.
- C. Start with complex vowel teams, then single consonants.
- D. Teach letter sounds only when they appear in read-alouds.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A first grader has learned short vowels and consonants but not vowel teams. The teacher's classroom library has 600 books, and the student likes stories about pets. Which text is best for his independent reading practice?

- A. A predictable book where he can memorize the repeated line.
- B. Any book, since all practice is equally helpful.
- C. A leveled pet story with many vowel-team words.
- D. A decodable book made mostly of short-vowel words like "The cat sat on a mat."

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A beginning reader keeps guessing words from pictures in her books. Which change in text is most likely to help?

- A.** Use books with larger pictures.
- B.** Remove all books until she knows every sound.
- C.** Switch to decodable texts aligned with the patterns she has been taught.
- D.** Give her harder books to challenge her.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A kindergartner writes “BK” for “bike” and “DG” for “dog.” She uses a green crayon and writes on the back of a menu. What does this show about her development?

- A.** She hears and represents beginning and ending sounds; next, teach middle vowel sounds.
- B.** She has no phonemic awareness.
- C.** She should copy words correctly and stop spelling on her own.
- D.** She should use paper instead of a menu.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher wants evidence that a child can now hear every sound in a short word, though not yet conventional spelling. Which spelling of “cake” shows this?

- A.** “cake”
- B.** “KAK”
- C.** “XRTQ”
- D.** “K”

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A kindergartner has trouble rhyming, still confuses letter sounds after a year of good instruction, and has a parent with a reading disability. He is excellent at puzzles and has an older cousin in fifth grade. What should the teacher consider?

- A. These are early signs of dyslexia risk; share concerns and provide more intensive, explicit phonological and phonics support.
- B. He cannot have dyslexia because he does not reverse letters.
- C. His puzzle skill shows he is fine.
- D. Dyslexia cannot be addressed until third grade, so wait.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which description best matches the core difficulty in dyslexia?

- A. A visual problem of seeing letters backward.
- B. A lack of interest in reading.
- C. Low general intelligence.
- D. Difficulty with the sound structure of language, leading to trouble decoding and spelling.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A first-grade teacher plans to screen reading skills only for the four students she is most worried about. Her room is next to the music room, and the class has 22 students. What is the concern with this plan?

- A. The music room noise will make results invalid.
- B. The screener will diagnose those four students with dyslexia.
- C. Screening should wait until the end of the year.
- D. Tier 1 screening should include every student so hidden risks are found early.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

During a PK read-aloud about a farm, the teacher wants to build vocabulary and oral language. The rug is shaped like a map, and snack comes next. Which approach best reflects dialogic reading?

- A. Pause to ask open questions, expand children's answers with new words, and have them repeat the fuller sentence.
- B. Finish quickly because snack is next.
- C. Read straight through without stopping so the story flows.
- D. Ask only yes/no questions.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A first-grade teacher is introducing the word “said.” She has a word wall with 40 words and a new set of magnetic letters. Which approach best follows the science of reading?

- A. Add it to the word wall and move on.
- B. Have students memorize the word's shape as a whole picture.
- C. Map the sounds /s/ /ě/ /d/ to letters, noting that “ai” is the part to learn by heart.
- D. Treat every letter in “said” as irregular.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

In the word “was,” which part would a teacher mark as the “heart” part to learn by heart?

- A. The “w.”
- B. The whole word.
- C. The “a,” which makes an unexpected /ŭ/ sound.
- D. The “s,” because it sounds like /z/.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer B Concept 1

A four-year-old ~~who loves trucks and has a baby brother~~ holds a picture book upside down and tells the story by looking at the pictures, turning pages from back to front. Which skill should the teacher focus on?

Target word: concept of print **Decides:** Book orientation and page order.

A	Camouflage	Interest does not teach how print works.
B	Correct	Book handling and directionality are concepts of print.
C	Adjacent category	Too advanced before basic print concepts.
D	Confusion set	He is not yet reading connected text.

2. Answer B Concept 2

A kindergarten team is planning phonics for the year. ~~Their school has a large garden and a new playground.~~ Which approach best reflects systematic, explicit phonics?

Target word: systematic, explicit phonics **Decides:** Planned sequence, taught directly.

A	Camouflage	Themes do not define a phonics sequence.
B	Correct	Systematic order and explicit teaching.
C	Inverted operation	Sequence should move from simple to complex.
D	Dropped element	Incidental teaching drops the planned sequence.

3. Answer D Concept 3

A first grader has learned short vowels and consonants but not vowel teams. ~~The teacher's classroom library has 600 books, and the student likes stories about pets.~~ Which text is best for his independent reading practice?

Target word: choose connected text **Decides:** Text should match taught patterns.

A	Adjacent category	Encourages memorizing instead of decoding.
B	Absolute language	Untaught patterns push guessing.
C	Camouflage	Matches interest but not taught patterns.
D	Correct	Lets him practice patterns he has learned.

4. Answer C Concept 3 • transfer

A beginning reader keeps guessing words from pictures in her books. Which change in text is most likely to help?

Target word: reverse: from behavior to text choice **Decides:** Guessing signals text beyond her decoding skills.

A	Inverted operation	Strengthens the guessing habit.
B	Absolute language	She needs connected text practice matched to her skills.
C	Correct	Makes decoding possible and useful.
D	Adjacent category	More untaught patterns increase guessing.

5. Answer A Concept 4

A kindergartner writes “BK” for “bike” and “DG” for “dog.” ~~She uses a green crayon and writes on the back of a menu.~~ What does this show about her development?

Target word: read invented spelling as data **Decides:** She represents beginning and ending sounds.

A	Correct	Early phonetic spelling; vowels come next.
B	Inverted operation	Correct first and last sounds show real awareness.
C	Adjacent category	Invented spelling builds sound-letter skill.
D	Camouflage	Writing surface is irrelevant.

6. Answer B Concept 4 • transfer

A teacher wants evidence that a child can now hear every sound in a short word, though not yet conventional spelling. Which spelling of “cake” shows this?

Target word: reverse: pick the sample from the stage **Decides:** Every sound represented, unconventional.

A	Inverted operation	Conventional spelling, a later stage.
B	Correct	Represents /k/ /ā/ /k/, all three sounds.
C	Confusion set	Random letters, an earlier stage.
D	Dropped element	Only the first sound.

7. Answer A Concept 5

A kindergartner has trouble rhyming, still confuses letter sounds after a year of good instruction, and has a parent with a reading disability. ~~He is excellent at puzzles and has an older cousin in fifth grade.~~ What should the teacher consider?

Target word: early dyslexia risk **Decides:** Phonological difficulty plus family history despite instruction.

A	Correct	Early phonological signs plus family history warrant action.
B	Confusion set	Reversals are common in all young children and do not define dyslexia.
C	Camouflage	Visual-spatial strength does not rule out a phonological difficulty.
D	Absolute language	Early identification and support are most effective.

8. Answer D Concept 5 • transfer

Which description best matches the core difficulty in dyslexia?

Target word: reverse: definition from signs **Decides:** Phonological processing and decoding.

A	Confusion set	A common myth.
B	Inverted operation	Low interest can result from, not cause, dyslexia.
C	Adjacent category	Dyslexia is unrelated to intelligence.
D	Correct	The core is phonological.

9. Answer D Concept 6

A first-grade teacher plans to screen reading skills only for the four students she is most worried about. ~~Her room is next to the music room,~~ and the class has 22 students. What is the concern with this plan?

Target word: universal screening **Decides:** All students should be screened.

A	Camouflage	Not the main concern with the plan.
B	Adjacent category	Screeners flag risk; they do not diagnose.
C	Inverted operation	Screening early allows early support.
D	Correct	Universal screening catches students a teacher may miss.

10. Answer A Concept 7

During a PK read-aloud about a farm, the teacher wants to build vocabulary and oral language. ~~The rug is shaped like a map, and snack comes next.~~ Which approach best reflects dialogic reading?

Target word: dialogic reading **Decides:** Prompt, evaluate, expand, repeat with children talking.

A	Correct	Children become active talkers with adult expansions.
B	Camouflage	Schedule does not decide the method.
C	Dropped element	Drops the child talk that builds language.
D	Adjacent category	Limits the language children produce.

11. Answer C Concept 8

A first-grade teacher is introducing the word “said.” ~~She has a word wall with 40 words and a new set of magnetic letters.~~ Which approach best follows the science of reading?

Target word: teach an irregular word **Decides:** Map regular sounds, mark the irregular part.

A	Dropped element	Display without instruction drops the mapping.
B	Confusion set	Word shape is not how words are stored.
C	Correct	Connects sounds to spelling and isolates the irregular part.
D	Absolute language	Only one part is irregular.

12. Answer C Concept 8 • transfer

In the word “was,” which part would a teacher mark as the “heart” part to learn by heart?

Target word: reverse: identify the irregular part **Decides:** “w” and “s” follow expected sounds; “a” says /ŭ/.

A	Inverted operation	“w” makes its expected sound.
B	Absolute language	Only one part is irregular.
C	Correct	The other letters are decodable.
D	Adjacent category	“s” as /z/ is a common, expected pattern.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	8	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	7	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	5	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Concepts of print	Young children must learn how print works: print carries meaning, left-to-right and top-to-bottom tracking, return sweep, and the difference between letters, words, and spaces.	Assuming children who enjoy books already know how print works.	A preschooler who “reads” a book by telling the story from pictures or points randomly.
2	Systematic, explicit phonics	Letter-sound patterns are taught directly in a planned sequence from simple to complex, with immediate practice in reading and spelling words.	Teaching phonics only when patterns happen to come up in books.	Planning the order of phonics instruction.
3	Decodable texts	Beginning readers practice with texts made mostly of letter-sound patterns they have been taught, so they apply decoding instead of guessing.	Giving beginners predictable or leveled texts full of untaught patterns.	Choosing connected text for a new reader.
4	Invented spelling shows phonemic knowledge	Early spellings reveal which sounds a child hears and can represent; a child's progression moves from random letters to beginning/ending sounds to full phonetic spellings to conventional patterns.	Treating all invented spelling as errors to be corrected rather than data.	A writing sample such as “KT” for “cat” or “CAT” vs. “kat.”
5	Dyslexia: phonological core and early screening	Dyslexia is primarily a difficulty with phonological processing and word decoding despite adequate instruction; early warning signs include trouble with rhyming, letter-sound learning, and family history.	Believing dyslexia means seeing letters backward or that it cannot be identified until third grade.	A young child with persistent sound-letter trouble.
6	Universal screening in Tier 1	All students are screened several times a year so those at risk receive support early; screening flags risk, it does not diagnose.	Screening only students the teacher is worried about, or treating a screener as a diagnosis.	A beginning-of-year plan for identifying risk.
7	Dialogic reading and oral language	During read-alouds, adults prompt children to talk, expand their responses, and use new words, which builds vocabulary and language.	Reading straight through while children listen silently.	A read-aloud in PK or kindergarten.
8	Teaching irregular high-frequency words	Teach high-frequency words by mapping the regular sounds and marking only the irregular part to learn “by heart.”	Teaching all sight words as whole shapes to memorize.	A word such as “said” or “was.”

Course scope (public description): Early Literacy Methods is a specialized course designed for educators and professionals passionate about nurturing literacy skills in young children. This course offers an in-depth exploration

of the foundational concepts and practices essential for promoting literacy development in early childhood through the science of reading. Emphasizing the critical development in grades PK to third grade, the curriculum covers topics such as phonemic awareness, language acquisition, and emergent reading and writing skills. Candidates learn how to create stimulating and inclusive literacy environments, use developmentally appropriate materials, and engage with a variety of high-quality core instruction as part of Tier 1 multi-tiered systems of support and assessment (MTSS) suited to the various needs of young learners, including learners with dyslexia. Additionally, the course incorporates the latest research in early childhood literacy focusing on the science of reading and best practices for how children learn to read and write. Through a blend of theoretical knowledge and practical application, this course aims to prepare candidates with the tools to effectively guide and inspire early literacy development in their classrooms.